

Working Mother/Mothering Worker

Throughout, all participants speak over each other and do not directly respond to the other participants.

Video (title slide): Black slide with white text: "Working Mother/Mothering Worker." Fade into new white text that reads "Featuring: Mothering Worker (MW), Dad, Kid, Demanding Boss (DB), 'Supportive' Employer (SE)"

Video: Fade into a black background with a woman (Mothering Worker) centered, reading from an offscreen teleprompter. Her demeanor is smiling and optimistic.

Mothering Worker (MW): Women everywhere are refusing to go back to the pre-COVID status quo.

Video: Title appears at the bottom of the screen in a blue box: "Work-Life Balance: Ditch the Guilt, Negotiate for Flexibility, and Find Equality at Work and at Home"

MW: We're prioritizing work-life balance. If you're lucky, you—

Video: White word bubbles appear on screen against the black background: "Kid: Can I have a snack?" and "Dad: I'm going to be out of town for a conference for the next week."

Kid (interrupting, from offscreen): Can I have a snack?

Video: Kid appears in front of MW, handing her a toy (which she puts down the front of her shirt) and a book (which she holds in her right arm).

Kid: I need you to take me to Jackson's house!

Video: Kid exits stage left.

MW: enjoy your work enough to feel the pull of wanting to be both at work and at home.

Video: Dad appears from stage left and hands MW a bag, which she puts over her left shoulder.

Dad (interrupting): I'm going to be out of town for a conference for the next week.

Video: Dad exits stage right.

MW: Working motherhood isn't a choice, it's a reality for many women. Here's how to ditch the guilt, negotiate for flexibility and find equality at work and at home.

Video: White word bubble appears on screen: "SE: We're happy to offer you 6 weeks unpaid leave!"

Supportive Employer (SE) (interrupting, from offscreen): We're happy to offer you 6 weeks of unpaid leave.

Video: SE appears stage right, hands MW several folders, which she places on top of the book she's already holding, and exits stage left. Demanding Boss (DB) enters from stage left and hands MW a bag.

MW: In order to make change—

Demanding Boss (DB) (interrupting): I need this from you by 8am tomorrow!

Video: White word bubble appears on screen: "DB: I need this from you by 8am tomorrow!" MW puts the book and folders in the bag that was just handed to her and puts it over her right shoulder.

MW: and, yes, make money—you've got to stay in the game. Give moms the tools to thrive—

Video: White word bubble appears on screen: "Dad: The kids are fighting. What's for dinner."

Dad (interrupting): The kids are fighting. What's for dinner.

Video: Dad enters from stage left, hands MW a bag that she puts over her left shoulder, and exits stage right.

MW: and we'll be your best employees. In the past—

Video: White word bubble appears on screen under the first "Dad" word bubble: "Dad: The kids are fighting!"

Dad (interrupting): The kids are fighting!

MW: we might have just shrugged our shoulders and accepted it—

Video: White word bubble appears on screen: "Kid: Can I have more screen time, Mommy?"

Kid (interrupting): Can I have more screen time, Mommy?

Video: Kid enters from stage right, hands MW several books that she holds in her left arm, and exits stage left.

MW: grumbling that “this is just the price we have to pay.” But this time, we know better. Feeling overwhelmed is normal.

DB (interrupting): You have to be in the office at least 3 days a week.

Video: White word bubble appears on screen: “DB: You have to be in the office at least 3 days a week.” DB enters from stage right, hands MW several folders, which she adds to the books she’s holding, and exits stage left.

MW: Most moms who work outside the home are back on the job before they’re emotionally or physically ready. This is natural and it’s not your fault. If you look frazzled, that’s not a bad thing. Just look frazzled and like you’re dealing with it.

SE (interrupting): You can finish your work after 8pm.

Video: White word bubble appears on screen: “SE: You can finish your work after 8pm.”

Video: SE enters from stage left, hands MW a bag, and exits stage right.

MW: That’s impressive! It’s O.K. to feel conflicted or overworked.

Video: MW puts the books and folders she’s holding into the bag she’s just been handed and puts the bag over her right shoulder.

MW: Or even lazy! That’s human. Going forward, we need increased support to do our jobs well—

Video: White word bubble appears on screen: “DB: I sent you an email last night, and you didn’t respond.”

DB (interrupting): I sent you an email last night, and you didn’t respond.

Video: DB enters from stage right, hands MW a bag, and exits stage left. MW puts the bag over her left shoulder.

MW: and keep our families afloat. Motherhood is a strength at work. Working makes you a good mom.

Video: Dad enters stage right. White word bubble appears on screen: "Dad: I'm happy to help more if you just tell me what you need me to do."

Dad (interrupting): I'm happy to help more if you just tell me what you need me to do.

Video: Dad pauses while he delivers his line, then exits stage left.

MW: Talk about your kids at work. Talk about your work at home. Talk about how your partner didn't get to take parental leave. Take the call from the school nurse. Build—

Kid (interrupting): Can I have a snack?

Video: White word bubble appears on screen: "Kid: Can I have a snack?" Kid walks from stage left to stage right in front of MW without pausing.

MW: equity at home. Use your commute.

Video: White word bubble appears on screen under Kid's word bubble: "Dad: The kids are asking for a snack!"

Dad (interrupting): The kids are asking for a snack!

Video: Dad walks from stage left to stage right in front of MW without pausing.

MW: Of course, there will be plenty of moms who can't afford to risk a gap in employment. But that's exactly why the rest of us have to speak out, to push for change.

Video: MW stops talking and looks up for the first time, her eyes following the characters passing in front of her as her expression shifts slowly from optimistic and hopeful to increasingly sad and discouraged.

Video: White word bubble appears on screen: "SE: Just tell me if you need more flexibility!"

SE: Just tell me if you need more flexibility.

Video: SE walks from stage right to stage left in front of MW without pausing.

Video: Large white words appear in the bottom half of the screen in parenthesis and remain on the screen, covering the lower part of MW's body: "(And by the way, this is not a bad position for men to take, as well.)" MW begins to slowly sink down, lower and lower on the screen. Eventually, she is completely behind the words.

Video: White word bubble appears on screen while SE's word bubble and words in parentheses are still there: "DB: We need you to stay late to finish this project!"

DB: We need you to stay late to finish this project!

Video: DB walks from stage left to stage right in front of MW without pausing.

Dad (from offscreen): The kids are asking for a snack!

Video: White word bubbles appear on screen while SE's and DB's word bubbles and words in parentheses are still there: "Dad: The kids are asking for a snack!" and "Dad: When's dinner?"

Dad (from offscreen): When's dinner?

Video: MW's head disappears from the bottom of the screen.

Kid (from offscreen): Can I have a snack?

Video: White word bubble appears on screen while SE's, DB's, and Dad's word bubbles, along with words in parentheses, are still there: "Kid: Can I have a snack?" Word bubbles all disappear at once, leaving a black screen with the words in parenthesis: "(And by the way, this is not a bad position for men to take, as well.)"

SE (from offscreen): I volunteered you to lead the discussion on work-life balance!

Video: Words in parentheses cross-fade to a final word bubble, centered on the black screen: "SE: I volunteered you to lead the discussion on work-life balance!" Fade to black.

Scripts by Role

Mothering Worker (MW)'s Monologue:

Women everywhere are refusing to go back to the pre-COVID status quo. We're prioritizing work-life balance.

If you're lucky, you enjoy your work enough to feel the pull of wanting to be both at work and at home. Working motherhood isn't a choice, it's a reality for many women. Here's how to ditch the guilt, negotiate for flexibility and find equality at work and at home. In order to make change—and, yes, make money—you've got to stay in the game. Give moms the tools to thrive, and we'll be your best employees. In the past, we might have just shrugged our shoulders and accepted it, grumbling that "this is just the price we have to pay." But this time, we know better.

Feeling overwhelmed is normal. Most moms who work outside the home are back on the job before they're emotionally or physically ready. This is natural and it's not your fault. If you look frazzled, that's not a bad thing. Just look frazzled and like you're dealing with it. That's impressive! It's O.K. to feel conflicted or overworked. Or even lazy! That's human.

Going forward, we need increased support to do our jobs well and keep our families afloat. Motherhood is a strength at work. Working makes you a good mom. Talk about your kids at work. Talk about your work at home. Talk about how your partner didn't get to take parental leave. Take the call from the school nurse. Build equity at home. Use your commute.

Of course, there will be plenty of moms who can't afford to risk a gap in employment. But that's exactly why the rest of us have to speak out, to push for change.

Kid:

Can I have a snack? I need you to take me to Jackson's house!
Can I have more screen time, Mommy?
Can I have a snack?
Can I have a snack?

Dad:

I'm going to be out of town for a conference for the next week.
The kids are fighting. What's for dinner.
The kids are fighting!
I'm happy to help more if you just tell me what you need me to do.
The kids are asking for a snack!
The kids are asking for a snack! When's dinner!

"Supportive" Employer:

We're happy to offer you 6 weeks of unpaid leave.
You can finish your work after 8pm.
Just tell me if you need flexibility!
I volunteered you to lead the discussion on work-life balance.

Demanding Boss:

I need this from you by 8am tomorrow!
You have to be in the office at least 3 days a week.
I sent you an email last night, and you didn't respond.
We need you to stay late tonight to finish this project!

Cast

Mothering Worker (MW): Marion Wolfe

Dad/"Supportive" Employer (SE): Michelle LaFrance
Kid/Demanding Boss (DB): Lydia McDermott

MW's Monologue adapted from

"How to Be Mostly O.K. (and Occasionally Fantastic) at the Whole Working Mom Thing." by
Lauren Smith Brody

"Is This the Moment When Working Moms Finally 'Have It All'? Not Exactly." by Reshma Saujani